

Sachin's best points are that he's both powerful and technically good. He has a very stable front leg and great coordination," he adds.

"Sachin shouldn't chase 95m"

Klaus doesn't think Sachin's 86.27m throw in Tokyo will remain his Personal Best for long. "Do I think he can throw 90 metres? Of course he can. It's very possible," he says.

But he cautions against obsession with distance. "I don't even think 95 metres is impossible for Sachin. But you need to be realistic. Neeraj threw 86m in 2016 and it took him nearly nine years to get to 90 in competition. Neeraj started young. He was 18 when he threw 86m. Sachin is around 24 or 25. And the road to 95m is very stony. It takes a lot out of you. (Johannes) Vetter threw 97m and paid the price with his body. That number can play with your head too," he says.

Instead, Klaus wants Sachin to stabilise his current level. "We should avoid all this talk of 90 metres. It should be about consistency. We had this young German (Max Dehning) who threw 90 but now he's at 75. All this hype about metres is useless. It's counterproductive. Sachin needs to stabilise at 85-86m, as Neeraj did around 88. If he can throw 85-86m anytime, he'll always be in contention for the Commonwealth Games and the Olympics," he says.

Neeraj can still win Olympic gold

Neeraj, Klaus believes, will remain in the mix for the Los Angeles Games. The Tokyo result was a setback, but Klaus admits the injury Neeraj suffered beforehand made things difficult. "I didn't speak much to him after the final. He looked very upset and disappointed, and it's hard to know what to say then. He's a good sportsperson. He congratulated Keshorn and said he'd do better. I think he had some health problems and couldn't train for two weeks. He was very good in qualification but couldn't repeat it the next day. Sometimes it's just luck," he says.

Could Neeraj have trained differently to avoid injury? Klaus refuses to speculate. "I don't know what the training program looks like,

so I can't say he should have done something differently. Injuries are unpredictable. There's always a risk when you're training. Neeraj once aggravated his groin injury making a very easy throw. Once he fractured his finger doing hurdle jumps. If you don't want to get injured, stay home — and then you might fall down the stairs!" he laughs.

What Klaus hopes Neeraj can avoid, though, is the pressure. "There's so much pressure on him. I'd suggest to Indians: put less pressure on your athletes. Enjoy them and let them enjoy the competition. There's no point giving them advice from outside," he says. What also bothered him was the hype around the 90m barrier. "Everyone made it out to be a kind of club. That influences the public and reaches the athlete. Of course, at Worlds and Olympics, there's always pressure, but the extra noise doesn't help," he says.

Neeraj has handled that noise well for years, but this time things didn't fall into place. "He was surely one of the contenders for a medal. He was the World champion and Olympic silver medallist, but now he's the hunted," says Klaus.

Still, Klaus believes Neeraj has it in him to return to the podium. "He has the capacity to win another Olympic medal. Jan Zelezny did it three times, so he knows what it takes mentally. Neeraj's still young, 27 or 28. He aims high but isn't overconfident — that's important. He's dealt with injury before, and he's thrown 90 metres. He also has a very good physiotherapist in Ishan Marwaha, who's worked with him for years. That helps. I think he'll be in contention again," says Klaus.

There will be other challengers, of course. "Anderson (Peters) and Arshad (Nadeem) are about the same age as Neeraj. For the next three years, these three will be at the top. It's hard to say who will come out on top at the big events. You can do everything right and still have the bad luck that Weber had in Tokyo," he says.

Klaus is confident that Walcott, too, can stay in the mix despite being in his thirties. "I think Keshorn can

still be competitive at the Los Angeles Games. He's been doing this since he was 18 and stayed consistent. It's not just about age; it's about biological age, health, and the support team. Can he bring his body to the right condition at the right time? Weber, Peters, Neeraj, and Keshorn all have the brains to be champions. They can think about their training and reflect on what they're doing," he says.

Olympic gold still the favourite

Despite having worked with both, Klaus says he can't compare Neeraj and Walcott. "They have very different personalities and very

